THE P4 PLAN

- According to the latest NITI Aayog report, Andhra Pradesh has a multidimensional poverty rate of 6.06% (2019-2021). India's average: 14.96%
- Andhra's multidimensional poverty index (MPI) decreased to 0.025 from 0.053 (2015-16), making it the ninth least poor state in India
- The Public-Private-People Partnership (P4) initiative aims to make the state poverty-free by 2029 by pairing the wealthiest 10% with the poorest 20%
- Affluent individuals (Margadarsis) will mentor and support underprivileged families (Bangaru Kutumbams), going beyond mere financial aid
- The state will facilitate these partnerships and ensure transparency via digital dashboards and oversight

high-net worth individuals at home and the Telugu diaspora—can offer career guidance, help with financial decision-making, provide access to professional networks or even chip in with tuition fees or working capital. Those with limited time can help by contributing funds for education, healthcare or infrastructure for beneficiaries at the individual, family or village level. "So far, charitable efforts have been individual [driven], while the government has introduced Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR). But this initiative is unique as it provides an institutionalised platform for direct interaction between Margadarsis and Bangaru Kutumbams," says Naidu.

The first phase has already begun. Two Bangaru Kutumbams were introduced to three prominent Margadarsis—Megha Engineering and Infrastructure Ltd (MEIL) managing director P.V. Krishna Reddy, Greenko CEO Anil Kumar Chalamalasetty and entrepreneur Sajjan Kumar Goenka. The families spoke about their struggles, particularly their inability to fund their children's education. Reacting to this, Krishna Reddy revealed that he had already surveyed a mandal in Krishna district and was prepared to adopt it in its entirety.

This is just the start. The government has identified two million of the state's most deprived families for inclusion in the programme, with more to be added later. The immediate goal is to facilitate the "adoption" of 500,000 of them by August 15. While the government will structure the initiative and ensure transparency through digital dashboards, it has kept itself out of financial transactions. Margadarsis are free to choose the families they wish to support, and once both parties are comfortable, government personnel will facilitate their interaction.

The initiative is being positioned as a transformative model, one that could redefine poverty alleviation in India. To ensure long-term impact, the state is also working on improving the delivery of basic amenities—providing house sites, sanitation, LPG connections, reliable power, high-speed internet, and even incentives for entrepreneurship. A 'P4 Society' with Naidu as its chairperson and deputy CM Pawan Kalyan as vice-chairperson is being established to oversee state-wide implementation, with chapters at the district, assembly constituency and village secretariat levels. These will comprise industry leaders, philanthropists, CSR heads and civil society organisations as well. Naidu has high expectations. "So far, no plan of mine has failed," he asserts. "By next Ugadi, we will assess progress and, by 2029, Margadarsis should uplift all Bangaru Kutumbams out of poverty through a structured and scalable model."

WHILE NAIDU CALLS P4 A GAME-CHANGER, CRITICS SEE IT AS AN ABDICATION OF THE GOVT'S RESPONSIBILITY

But the initiative has also sparked debate. While Naidu presents P4 as a "game-changer", critics see it as an abdication of state responsibility. The opposition Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party (YSRCP) has dismissed it as an extension of Naidu's pro-privatisation stance. "Naidu's P4 initiative is aimed at avoiding responsibility and masking his inability to fulfil the 'super six' poll promises," says YSRCP leader A. Rambabu. "The man who claimed to create wealth now entrusts poverty alleviation to the wealthy, exposing his manipulative politics."

Others see merit in the approach but caution against its challenges. "Naidu has set high expectations as a visionary. But achieving zero poverty is easier said than done," says B.V. Muralidhar, a political scientist at Sri Venkateswara University, Tirupati. "It's not easy to achieve, considering the diverse stand of political parties." The scale and ambition of P4 are unprecedented, but whether it thrives or flounders will depend on sustained engagement from the private sector and civil society. If successful, it could establish Telugu people as "global role models in philanthropy", in Naidu's words. If not, it risks becoming another well-intended but impractical policy, lost in the complexities of political and economic realities. ■